beneficial impact on India's own thinking about regionalism. It now seeks consciously to ensure that neighbours also benefit from its growth and prosperity. The growing number of regional infrastructure projects supported by India is a sign of its seriousness in this resolve.

ASEAN could also be credited with contributing significantly to India's understanding of the role that people of Indian origin abroad can play in its relationship with the world. Indeed, there are few better examples of networking and bridging than the diaspora of this region. Not least is the catalytic role that South-East Asia has played in the revival of India's historical linkages and interests. The Nalanda concept, as we know it today, literally started in Singapore. Since then, it has emerged as an encouragement to a broader Indian embrace of its Buddhist history and heritage and a more central place for that in its people-to-people contacts.

In the past, the contrasting world that existed east of India was a bridge too far for its strategic horizon. When the two worlds collided, as they did in the early 1960s, it was more to India's peril than benefit. But the engagement with ASEAN has begun a socialization process where India's interests eastwards have steadily developed. For this to gather momentum, both India and its eastern partners will have to step out of their comfort zone. Where such interests are supported by values, then convergences could take root more definitively. Whether the traditional outlook of nations can accommodate more contemporary concerns remains to be seen. India and Japan in particular have a gulf of mindsets to cross. Reconciling Indian improvization with Japanese perseverance requires a strong sense of purpose backed by sustained efforts. The test for this relationship is to overcome unfamiliarity and distance, very different from the usual problems of divergences and irritants. That politics is in command as Japan looks at India could well mean a lot. Because in reality, it is trade that follows the flag. If Noida and Nagoya are to truly meet, it would add a new page to Asia's history. And then there may yet be another twist in a continental saga that could be less predestined than many assume.